

The Record of Jesus Christ

Pure evidentiary claim index

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Claims: 124 · Tiers: {"verified":42,"contested":18,"well_attested":47,"speculative":2,"interpretive":7,"literary_theological":3,"circumstantial":14}

Every claim is labeled by evidence tier. Proof-grade data is never conflated with literary or theological development. This PDF is a portable index; the live platform at veritasworldwide.com/record-of-jesus-christ remains the canonical interactive surface.

Methodology (summary)

Tiers: Verified · Well-Attested · Circumstantial · Contested · Interpretive · Speculative · Literary/Theological. Tools: multiple attestation, Nestle-Aland/UBS standards, archaeological dating with ranges, observational cosmology as science only.

[verified] ane-babylonian-chronicles

Babylonian Chronicles document Nebuchadnezzar’s campaigns against Jerusalem, providing independent chronological control for the late Iron Age Judah narrative.

[verified] ane-black-obelisk

The Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III depicts Jehu (or a representative) of Israel paying tribute — an extra-biblical visual control for the Omride/Jehu period.

[verified] ane-cyrus-cylinder

The Cyrus Cylinder (c. 539 BCE) records Achaemenid policy of restoring temples and returning displaced populations after the conquest of Babylon.

[contested] ane-exodus-historicity

The historicity and scale of an Israelite exodus from Egypt remain contested in critical scholarship.

[well_attested] ane-flood-literature

Mesopotamian flood traditions (Atrahasis, Gilgamesh XI) are independent literary parallels to Genesis flood narrative forms.

[well_attested] ane-hezekiah-lmlk

lmlk jar handles and related Judahite administrative seals concentrate in late eighth-century contexts associated with Hezekiah’s reign and Assyrian threat.

[well_attested] ane-inscription-map

Key West Semitic and Egyptian inscriptions relevant to Israel/Judah (Merneptah, Mesha, Tel Dan, Siloam, etc.) form a geographically distributed control set across Egypt, Transjordan, and the Galilee–Golan.

[verified] ane-merneptah

The Merneptah Stele (c. 1208 BCE) contains the earliest known extra-biblical reference to “Israel” as a people in Canaan.

[verified] ane-mesha

The Mesha Stele (c. 840 BCE) names Omri of Israel, Yahweh, and Moabite campaigns paralleling 2 Kings 3.

[verified] ane-tel-dan

The Tel Dan Stele (9th century BCE) attests the phrase “House of David” (bytdwd) outside the Bible.

[well_attested] ane-ugarit

Ugaritic texts (Ras Shamra) supply Northwest Semitic mythic and ritual parallels used in comparative study of Hebrew Bible poetry and divine council language.

[verified] arch-bar-kokhba

The Bar Kokhba revolt (132–135 CE) is archaeologically and papyrologically attested; its aftermath reshaped Judean demography and Jewish–Christian trajectories.

[well_attested] arch-capernaum

Capernaum (Kefar Nahum) was a fishing village on the Sea of Galilee with Early Roman occupation; a later synagogue stands over earlier remains.

[verified] arch-galilee-boat

The “Jesus Boat” (first-century Galilee boat, discovered 1986) illustrates fishing technology on the lake in the Early Roman period.

[contested] arch-james-ossuary

The so-called James ossuary inscription (“James son of Joseph brother of Jesus”) remains contested regarding authenticity of the brother phrase and provenance.

[contested] arch-jericho

Jericho’s Late Bronze destruction layers and relation to a conquest narrative remain a classic contested case in biblical archaeology.

[well_attested] arch-magdala

Magdala excavations reveal a first-century Galilean town with a synagogue and harbor installations, enriching the social map of Jesus’ activity zone.

[well_attested] arch-masada

Masada’s archaeology confirms a First Jewish Revolt–period fortress with Roman siege works; Josephus’s mass-suicide narrative is only partly controllable by material remains.

[well_attested] arch-nazareth

Nazareth existed as a small Jewish settlement in the Early Roman period; monumental first-century remains are limited.

[well_attested] arch-pool-bethesda

Excavations north of the Temple Mount have exposed twin pools matching John’s description of Bethesda with five porticoes (John 5) better than once assumed.

[verified] arch-sepphoris

Sepphoris (Zippori), ~6 km from Nazareth, was a significant urban center in Early Roman Galilee under Antipas.

[verified] arch-siloam

The Siloam Tunnel inscription (discovered 1880) describes construction of Hezekiah’s tunnel, matching 2 Kings 20:20 / 2 Chr 32:30 as royal hydraulic works.

[speculative] arch-talpiot

Talpiot “Jesus family tomb” statistical and onomastic claims are speculative and rejected by most specialists as identification of the New Testament Jesus.

[verified] arch-yehohanan

The crucified remains of Yehohanan son of Hagkol (Giv’at ha-Mivtar) provide osteological evidence of Roman crucifixion practice in Judea (nail through heel bone).

[well_attested] cosmo-age

Under Planck 2018 Λ CDM parameters, the universe age is approximately 13.8 billion years.

[well_attested] cosmo-bbn

Primordial abundances of light elements (tHe, D, ^3He , wLi) are broadly consistent with Big Bang nucleosynthesis predictions.

[verified] cosmo-cmb

The cosmic microwave background (CMB) is a near-isotropic blackbody at $T \approx 2.725$ K in the universe.

[verified] cosmo-cmb-power

The CMB angular power spectrum exhibits acoustic peaks whose positions and amplitudes constrain baryon density, dark matter density, and curvature in Λ CDM fits.

[verified] cosmo-expansion

Spectroscopic redshift of galaxies correlates with distance (Hubble–Lemaître law), indicating metric expansion of space.

[interpretive] cosmo-fine-tuning-params

Several dimensionless physical parameters appear finely constrained for complex chemistry; teleological interpretation is philosophical, not a scientific conclusion of this Record.

[well_attested] cosmo-matter-energy

Planck baseline Λ CDM reports cold dark matter and dark energy as dominant densities in the universe.

[contested] cosmo-nucleosynthesis-li

The cosmological lithium problem remains an open tension between standard BBN predictions and stellar abundance measurements.

[verified] ec-apostolic-fathers

The Apostolic Fathers (1 Clement, Didache, Ignatius, Polycarp, etc.) provide early non-NT Christian primary sources.

[verified] ec-athanasius

Athanasius, 39th Festal Letter (367 CE), lists the exact 27-book New Testament canon later ratified in the West.

[well_attested] ec-didache

The Didache preserves an early Christian “two ways” ethic, baptismal and eucharistic instructions, and itinerant ministry rules — dating commonly late 1st / early 2nd c.

[contested] ec-gospel-thomas

The Gospel of Thomas (Nag Hammadi) is a sayings gospel whose dating and dependence on canonical Gospels are contested.

[well_attested] ec-ignatius

Ignatius of Antioch’s letters (early 2nd c., authenticity of middle recension majority) show monepiscopacy advocacy and high Christological language in transit to martyrdom.

[verified] ec-irenaeus

Irenaeus (c. 180 CE) argues for a fourfold Gospel (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John) against alternative gospel usages.

[well_attested] ec-marcion

Marcion of Sinope (mid-2nd century) promulgated a reduced Gospel+Paul collection, prompting proto-orthodox canon and theological responses.

[well_attested] ec-muratorian

The Muratorian Fragment is an early (often 2nd-century, date contested) Latin canon list showing a nearly formed but not identical NT collection.

[literary_theological] ec-nicaea

The Council of Nicaea (325 CE) addressed Christological doctrine (homoousios) under Constantine; it did not create the NT canon list.

[interpretive] ec-update-triggers

This Record's perpetual update triggers include: new major papyri/majuscule publications, INTF Liste changes, peer-reviewed dig reports, and material consensus shifts in historical Jesus research.

[well_attested] hj-appearances

Early Christian proclamation included claims of post-crucifixion appearances to individuals and groups (1 Cor 15:3–8); the nature of those experiences is not scientifically settled.

[well_attested] hj-baptism

Baptism of Jesus by John the Baptist is widely judged historical under the criterion of embarrassment and multiple attestation.

[contested] hj-bethlehem

Bethlehem birth is narrated in Matthew and Luke with divergent infancy stories; historical verification is contested, while Nazareth association is stronger.

[well_attested] hj-caiaphas

An ossuary inscribed “Yehosef bar Qayafa” (discovered 1990) is widely identified with the high-priestly family of Caiaphas.

[verified] hj-crucifixion

Crucifixion of Jesus under Pontius Pilate (prefect of Judea c. 26–36 CE) is multiply attested and coheres with Roman practice.

[contested] hj-crucifixion-year

Crucifixion year is commonly constrained to c. 30–33 CE by Pilate's tenure (26–36), Passover weekday arguments, and astronomical full-moon tables — exact year remains debated.

[contested] hj-empty-tomb

Empty-tomb narratives appear in the canonical Gospels with differences; whether an empty tomb is historical is debated; early creed in 1 Cor 15 emphasizes appearances more than tomb logistics.

[well_attested] hj-existence

The existence of Jesus of Nazareth as a first-century Jewish man is the near-consensus position of critical historians of antiquity.

[well_attested] hj-gal2-conflict

Galatians 2 records a conflict between Paul and Cephas (Peter) at Antioch over table fellowship with gentiles — primary evidence of diversity and dispute in the earliest movement.

[well_attested] hj-galilee-context

Early Roman Galilee included agricultural villages, fishing economy on the lake, and nearby urban centers such as Sepphoris and Tiberias.

[contested] hj-herod-death

The death of Herod the Great is conventionally dated to 4 BCE (with minority arguments for 1 BCE / other), anchoring the latest plausible nativity window in Matthew's framework.

[well_attested] hj-james-leadership

James the brother of Jesus is attested as a Jerusalem leadership figure (Paul; Acts; Josephus Ant. 20.200) until his death c. 62 CE.

[well_attested] hj-kingdom-proclamation

A core historical judgment across diverse scholars is that Jesus proclaimed God's kingdom / reign as central to his public activity.

[contested] hj-language

Jesus likely spoke Aramaic as a primary vernacular; Greek exposure in Galilee is plausible; Hebrew literacy/use is debated for the population stratum.

[well_attested] hj-literacy

Literacy rates in Early Roman Judea/Galilee were limited relative to modern norms; most people encountered texts orally and through specialists.

[literary_theological] hj-magi-star

Magi and star narratives in Matthew 2 are literary-theological traditions; astronomical “explanations” are speculative correlations, not historical proof.

[interpretive] hj-miracles-method

Miracle narratives are not historically “verified” under naturalistic historical method; historians can study reports, meanings, and social effects of wonder-traditions.

[contested] hj-pauline-chronology

Pauline absolute chronology is reconstructed from Acts, the letters, and external anchors (Gallio inscription at Delphi); competing schemes (Ramsay, Knox, Hyldahl, et al.) differ by several years.

[circumstantial] hj-peter-rome

Peter’s presence and martyrdom in Rome are early traditions (1 Clement; later Acts of Peter) with varying historical confidence; New Testament itself does not narrate a Roman martyrdom.

[verified] hj-pilate-stone

The Pilate Stone (Caesarea Maritima, 1961) independently attests Pontius Pilate as prefect of Judea.

[contested] hj-quirinius

Luke’s census notice linking Jesus’ birth to a registration under Quirinius (6 CE) is a classic chronological problem relative to a Herodian birth before 4 BCE.

[literary_theological] hj-resurrection-hist

Claims of bodily resurrection are theological assertions; historians can document early belief and proclamation, not laboratory verification of the event.

[well_attested] hj-table-fellowship

Traditions of Jesus’ open table fellowship with “sinners” and tax collectors are widely treated as historically plausible under embarrassment and multiple attestation.

[well_attested] hj-temple-action

An action by Jesus in the Temple (disruption of commerce / symbolic demonstration) is multiply attested; interpretation ranges from prophetic sign to failed revolt cue.

[contested] hj-titles

Titles applied to Jesus (Messiah/Christ, Son of Man, Son of God, Lord) have layered historical and literary-theological histories; none should be treated as a single unproblematic first-century label without analysis.

[well_attested] hj-women-movement

Early Christian sources name women as patrons, witnesses, and coworkers (e.g., Mary Magdalene traditions; Romans 16 co-workers); social roles are historically reconstructable within limits.

[interpretive] mod-criteria-critique

Classical criteria of authenticity (embarrassment, dissimilarity, multiple attestation) are historiographical tools with known biases; recent memory and social approaches revise their use.

[interpretive] mod-criteria-embarrassment

The criterion of embarrassment is a heuristic, not a proof algorithm; it can be misapplied when later communities reframe “embarrassing” material.

[verified] mod-critical-editions

NA28/UBS5 (and ongoing ECM/INTF work) are the standard working critical texts of the Greek NT for academic use.

[verified] mod-digital-dss

The Leon Levy Dead Sea Scrolls Digital Library enables open inspection of high-resolution plate images for many Qumran manuscripts.

[well_attested] mod-genetics-limits

Ancient DNA of the Southern Levant informs regional demographic history; it cannot identify named New Testament individuals or prove specific genealogies in the Gospels.

[interpretive] mod-historical-jesus-quests

“Quests” for the historical Jesus are historiographical programs with shifting criteria; no single reconstruction commands universal assent.

[interpretive] mod-memory-approach

Social/collective memory approaches reconstruct how groups remembered Jesus rather than claiming verbatim ipsissima verba recovery.

[well_attested] mod-population-genetics

Population genetics of the Levant documents deep regional continuity with admixture layers; it does not identify individuals named in ancient texts.

[verified] mod-print-gutenberg

Print culture from Gutenberg onward multiplied biblical text access and stabilized vernacular canons — a reception-historical fact separate from first-century origins.

[well_attested] mod-radiocarbon-dss

Radiocarbon dating of selected Dead Sea Scrolls supports late Second Temple copy ranges broadly consistent with paleography.

[verified] mod-textus-receptus

The Textus Receptus tradition (Erasmus onward) underlies early modern vernacular Bibles but is not the base text of modern critical editions (NA/UBS).

[speculative] mod-turin-shroud

The Shroud of Turin is a medieval relic by mainstream radiocarbon dating (1988); authenticity as first-century burial cloth remains speculative/unverified for historical Jesus studies.

[verified] mod-war-70

The Jewish-Roman War culminating in the 70 CE destruction of the Temple is a primary historical horizon for dating and interpreting the Synoptic Gospels.

[well_attested] nc-james

Josephus, Antiquities 20.200 refers to “the brother of Jesus who is called Christ, James” in the account of Ananus’s execution of James — generally judged authentic.

[well_attested] nc-lucian

Lucian of Samosata (2nd c.) satirizes Christians and refers to their crucified sophist in Passing of Peregrinus — evidence of known Christian devotion, not independent biography.

[circumstantial] nc-mara

The Syriac letter of Mara bar Serapion mentions a “wise king” executed by the Jews; identification with Jesus is possible but not certain.

[verified] nc-pliny

Pliny the Younger, Epistles 10.96–97, describes early second-century Christian worship practices in Bithynia-Pontus and imperial policy under Trajan.

[circumstantial] nc-suetonius

Suetonius, Claudius 25.4, refers to disturbances in Rome impulsore Chresto — often discussed as a possible garbled reference to Christ-related conflict, but identification is uncertain.

[well_attested] nc-tacitus

Tacitus, Annals 15.44 reports that “Christus” was executed under Tiberius by the procurator Pontius Pilate and that the movement originated in Judea.

[well_attested] nc-tacitus-latin

Tacitus Annals 15.44 (Latin) states that Christus suffered the extreme penalty under Tiberius by sentence of procurator Pontius Pilate, and that the superstitio arose in Judea.

[circumstantial] nc-talmud

Certain Babylonian Talmud passages are sometimes read as hostile allusions to Jesus; dating, redaction, and identification are highly contested and often late.

[contested] nc-tf

Josephus, Antiquities 18.63–64 (Testimonium Flavianum) is widely judged partly authentic with Christian interpolations; fully authentic and fully forged positions are minorities.

[contested] nc-tf-reconstructions

Major scholarly reconstructions of the Testimonium Flavianum range from a short neutral core to more expansive partial authenticity; wholesale authenticity and wholesale forgery are minority poles.

[circumstantial] nc-thallus-phlegon

Later Christian authors cite Thallus and Phlegon regarding darkness at the crucifixion; the original pagan contexts are lost and the citations are mediated.

[verified] nt-comma-johanneum

The Comma Johanneum (1 John 5:7–8 Trinitarian formula in some later Latin/TR traditions) lacks early Greek support and is omitted in modern critical editions.

[well_attested] nt-ecm-method

The Editio Critica Maior (ECM) and CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method) represent the current large-scale critical reconstruction program for the Greek NT at INTF.

[well_attested] nt-eusebius-ch

Eusebius’s Church History is an indispensable but tendentious fourth-century source for earlier Christian literature and martyrdoms; source-critical caution is mandatory.

[contested] nt-gospel-dates

Critical consensus commonly dates Mark c. 65–75 CE, Matthew and Luke c. 80–90 CE, John c. 90–100 CE — with debate bands around each.

[verified] nt-homoeoteleuton

Many NT variants arise from ordinary scribal mechanics (homoeoteleuton, dittography, orthography), not theological conspiracy.

[contested] nt-john-historicity

John's Gospel is generally dated later than the Synoptics; its independent historical value for Jesus research is debated (high Christology vs. early tradition cores).

[verified] nt-majuscules

Fourth–fifth century majuscules (!5 01 Sinaiticus, A 02 Alexandrinus, B 03 Vaticanus) are foundational for the critical text.

[verified] nt-mark-ending

The longer ending of Mark (16:9–20) is absent from the earliest major witnesses (!5 NA28/UBS apparatuses).

[verified] nt-ms-count

Greek New Testament continuous-text manuscripts number on the order of several thousand, with additional lectionaries and versions.

[well_attested] nt-origen-hexapla

Origen's Hexapla (3rd c.) arranged Hebrew and Greek columns for comparative Old Testament textual work — a landmark of ancient textual criticism.

[verified] nt-p45-p46-p47

Chester Beatty papyri (P45, P46, P47) are major third-century witnesses to Gospels/Acts, Paul, and Revelation respectively.

[well_attested] nt-p52

Papyrus P52 (Rylands Greek P 457) is among the earliest surviving NT fragments (John 18), paleographically dated roughly to the second century CE.

[verified] nt-p66-p75

Bodmer papyri P66 and P75 are early substantial witnesses to John (and Luke/John for P75), foundational for Alexandrian text studies.

[well_attested] nt-paul-dates

Undisputed Pauline letters are typically dated c. 49–58 CE and are the earliest surviving Christian literary corpus.

[verified] nt-pericope-adulterae

John 7:53–8:11 (pericope adulterae) is widely judged a later insertion into John; early Greek continuous-text support is weak.

[contested] nt-synoptic-problem

The Synoptic Problem (literary relationship of Matthew, Mark, Luke) remains an active field; Markan priority is majority, Q hypothesis is majority but contested by Farrer and other models.

[verified] nt-textual-criticism

Greek New Testament continuous-text manuscripts number on the order of several thousand, with additional lectionaries and versions.

[verified] nt-variants

Hundreds of thousands of variant readings exist across the tradition; the vast majority are orthographic or trivial, while a minority affect meaning.

[well_attested] nt-western-text

The so-called Western text (e.g., Codex Bezae in Acts) exhibits expansive and paraphrastic tendencies relative to Alexandrian witnesses.

[verified] st-community-rule

Qumran sectarian texts (e.g., Community Rule 1QS, War Scroll 1QM, Pesharim) document a Jewish movement with distinctive purity, calendar, and eschatology in the late Second Temple period.

[verified] st-dss

Dead Sea Scrolls (discovered 1946–1956) preserve Hebrew Bible books and sectarian texts from roughly the third century BCE to first century CE.

[well_attested] st-dss-books

Among biblical DSS copies, Psalms, Deuteronomy, Isaiah, Exodus, and Genesis are among the most frequently attested books; Esther is not securely attested at Qumran.

[verified] st-herod-temple

Herod's expansion of the Jerusalem Temple platform is archaeologically and literarily well documented for the late first century BCE – first century CE.

[well_attested] st-isaiah-stability

Comparison of 1QIsaC (c. 2nd–1st century BCE) with the medieval Masoretic Text shows mostly orthographic and minor variants.

[verified] st-josephus-corpus

Flavius Josephus (late first century CE) is a principal non-Christian Jewish historian for Herodian and early Roman Judea.

[verified] st-lxx-textual

The Septuagint often preserves readings that differ from the medieval Masoretic Text; some align with Qumran Hebrew witnesses.

[well_attested] st-mishnah-context

The Mishnah (c. 200 CE redaction) and related Tannaitic literature preserve legal memory of Second Temple practice but are post-70 literary products requiring critical use for pre-70 reconstruction.

[well_attested] st-parties

Josephus and later rabbinic memory describe Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes as major Jewish schools; exact social demographics remain reconstructed.

[well_attested] st-pharisees-josephus

Josephus's descriptions of Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes are primary but tendentious; social realities were more complex than three-school schemes.

[verified] st-philo

Philo of Alexandria provides contemporary diaspora Jewish philosophical and exegetical context for the early first century CE.

[verified] st-prefecture

Roman Judea after 6 CE was administered by equestrian prefects (later procurators) based primarily at Caesarea, with troops and judicial powers including capital cases in practice.

[well_attested] st-temple-economy

The Jerusalem Temple system involved tithes, offerings, and currency exchange for worshippers — a documented economic-religious complex in Josephus and later rabbinic memory.